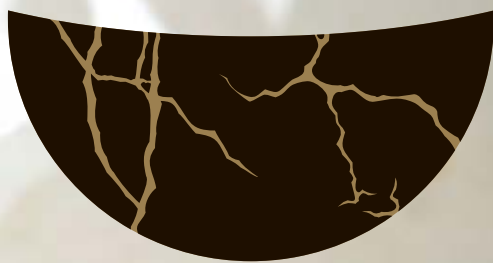


*A Devotional for
Lent & Easter 2026*

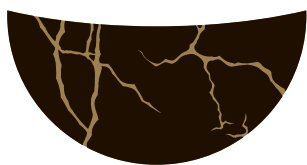


THE GOLD IN THE FRACTURE

A LENTEN JOURNEY OF MENDING



TRINITY LUTHERAN
CHURCH & SCHOOLS
BUILDING | BELONGING | BECOMING



THE GOLD IN THE FRACTURE

A LENTEN JOURNEY OF MENDING

*“When you are lonely,
may you be silently and gently led
to the holy well of your own spirit.
May you have the courage to honor your own soul.
May you recognize the treasure
that is hidden in the vessel of your brokenness.”*

John O’Donohue

To Bless the Space Between Us: A Book of Blessings, © 2008



THROWING THE CLAY: WHY “THE GREAT POTTERY THROW DOWN” INSPIRED OUR LENT

As your Minister of Music and Worship, my greatest joy is listening to the “well” of our communal life—the shared joys and fractures that define our spiritual formation. This Lent, we dive into those depths together. Our roadmap is the Revised Common Lectionary (Year A), which reminds us that the best stories are worth retelling because God is still speaking through them today.

However, a unique spark for this season’s theme came from an unlikely but beautiful place: the show *The Great Pottery Throw Down*. This program gathers amateur artists from a vast spectrum of experiences, ages, gender expressions, sexual identities, and races to form a vibrant community around the kiln.

Pottery is an ancient art that humanity has shared for millennia, and this endearing show captures the “breaking and the mending” in its truest form. I invite you to watch an episode or two during this season. As you witness the artists navigate the fragility of the clay—often through tears and triumph—I believe you will see our own Lenten journey reflected in the grit and the glaze.

We are the clay, the Spirit is the kiln, and the mending is where the gold resides. You are invited to the wheel.

In Christ,

David Horton

Minister of Music and Worship

OVERVIEW

KINTSUGI THEOLOGY

In the Japanese art of Kintsugi, broken pottery is repaired with lacquer mixed with powdered gold. The philosophy is simple: the break is part of the object's history, not something to be disguised.

Kintsugi Theology applies this to our faith. We believe in a “Wounded Healer” who kept His scars even after the Resurrection. This suggests that God doesn't want to erase our stories; God wants to redeem them. In this series, we view the Holy Spirit as the “Divine Gold” that fills our fractures, making our seams the strongest and most beautiful parts of who we are.

*“Kintsugi doesn't just repair the object;
it makes it a work of art.
The breakage is the opportunity.”*

Traditional Kintsugi Proverb

HOW TO ENGAGE THE MENDING

Each week of this journey follows a rhythm designed to align your heart, head, and hands with the Patient Artisan:

- **Read:** Enter the story through Scripture and through our “Kintsugi Theology”—learning to see our lives not as flawed vessels, but as masterpieces in the making.
- **Reflect:** Use the Multi-Generational questions to bridge the gaps between us, whether in family conversation or private journaling.
- **Watch:** Observe the beauty of the clay in *The Great Pottery Throw Down*, witnessing the vulnerability and resilience of the craft.
- **Practice:** Engage the “Physical Ritual” to move the theology from your mind into your hands.



- **Listen:** Allow the weekly song selection to breathe through your quiet moments and set the tone for your spirit.
- **Prayer:** Offer the jagged edges of your own life, the fractures in your relationships, and the broken heart of the world to the Golden Joiner.

THE COMPANION TOOLS

1. The Great Pottery Throw Down

To see the theology of clay in action, we recommend watching *The Great Pottery Throw Down*. It is a celebration of creativity, persistence, and the “soul” of the clay.

- **Where to Watch:** Available on HBO Max or Discovery+ (depending on your region). You can also find clips on YouTube.
- **What to Look For:** Pay attention to the “drying room” and the “kiln firings”—these are the moments where the potters have to let go and trust the process.

2. The “Gold in the Fracture” Spotify Playlist

Music has a way of seeping into our cracks when words fail. We have curated a playlist specifically for this series, featuring artists like Ingrid Michaelson, Johnny Cash, and Andra Day.

- **How to Listen:** Open your Spotify app, go to the “Search” tab, and tap the camera icon to scan the special code on the right, or simply use your phone’s camera to scan the QR on the left.



THE WEEKLY ROADMAP

	THEME	SCRIPTURE	POTTERY THROW DOWN ASSIGNMENT	SONG OF THE WEEK
Week 1	THE INVENTORY OF SHARDS	Isaiah 58:1-12 Matthew 4:1-11	S1,E1: The “Throwing” & first breakages.	<i>Bridge Over Troubled Water</i> Shawn Mendes
Week 2	THE NIGHT OF QUESTIONS	Genesis 12:1-4a John 3:1-17	S2,E3: The “Raku” (Fire & Smoke) episode	<i>Sound of Silence</i> Simon & Garfunkel
Week 3	THE WELL OF TRUTH	Exodus 17:1-7 John 4:5-42	S4,E1: The “Cheese Cellar” (Structural Integrity)	<i>Bridge Over Troubled Water</i> Jacob Collier
Week 4	THE SIGHT OF THE HEART	1 Samuel 16:1-13 John 9:1-41	S3,E4: The “Greek Statues” (Idealized Forms)	<i>Beautiful</i> India.Arie
Week 5	THE BREATH IN THE CRACKS	Ezekiel 37:1-14 John 11:1-45	S4,E10: The “Grand Final” (Large Scale Builds)	<i>Keep Breathing</i> Ingrid Michaelson
Holy Week	THE GREAT MENDING	Isaiah 53 Matthew 21 John 13	S4, E9: The “Raku Firing” (Thermal Shock)	<i>Hurt</i> Johnny Cash
Easter	THE GLORIFIED REVEAL	Jeremiah 31:1-6 John 20:1-18	Any Season Finale: The Grand Gallery reveal	<i>Rise Up</i> Andra Day

*And now, may you enter this Lent
with the courage to be “unpolished.”
May you have the strength to sit with your shards
and the patience to wait for the gold.
You are not a mistake to be fixed;
you are a masterpiece in the making.*

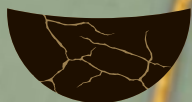
David Horton

Part I

LENTEN JOURNEY: THE FRACTURE

The Season of Assessment Lent is the time we spend in the Potter's workshop, allowing the Patient Artisan to turn us over in hand and see us as we truly are. We begin by admitting that we are not whole on our own; we are cracked by isolation, splintered by injustice, and fractured by the fear that our brokenness makes us worthless.

For these forty days, we stop the frantic work of hiding our seams. We lean into the "Fracture," trusting that the Source and Breath does not discard the damaged vessel, but prepares it for a beauty we cannot yet imagine.



THE GOLD IN THE FRACTURE

THE INVENTORY OF SHARDS

WEEK I

Ash Wednesday: The Shock of the Break
The First Week in Lent: The Inventory of Shards

*"I am forgotten like one dead;
I have become like a broken vessel."*

Psalm 31:12, Expanded Bible

POEM | *The Uses of Sorrow*

(In my sleep I dreamed this poem)

Someone I loved once gave me
a box full of darkness.

It took me years to understand
that this, too, was a gift.

Mary Oliver

from "Thirst" © 2007

READ | *Isaiah 58:1-12*

REFLECT | *The Repairer of the Breach*

The Divine Voice through the prophet is not interested in religious theatre. The Holy One is not "impressed" by our bowing heads or our sackcloth if our hands remain clenched in fists of oppression. Isaiah 58 presents us with a community addicted to its own image—trying to look unblemished while the foundations of justice are crumbling.

If our spiritual practice doesn't result in "breaking the yoke" of the marginalized, it is a hollow vessel. The "True Fast" is the intentional



breaking of our own comfort so that others might breathe. The Creator suggests that the “gold” in our lives isn’t found in how well we perform rituals, but in how we respond to the “breaks” in the world around us. God is not asking for a pristine, isolated bowl; **The Spirit is asking for a vessel that pours out.**

The passage concludes with the beautiful title: “The Repairer of the Breach” (NRSVUE). To the Mender of All, a “breach” is not a reason to discard the city, but a call to action. **We are invited to be the “gold” that fills the jagged, dangerous spaces of our society.** We are not called to build new, separate walls; we are called to mend the ones we have so that the world can become a “dwelling place” again.

READ | *Matthew 4:1-11*

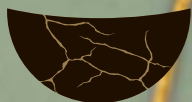
REFLECT | *The Desert and the Drying Room*

Immediately following the “living water” of baptism, The Spirit leads Christ into the wilderness. In the art of pottery, this is the “Drying Room”—a place of intense, quiet vulnerability. If a pot dries too quickly, it cracks; if it holds too much moisture, it explodes in the heat. The desert is where the “addiction to autonomy”¹ is finally confronted.

The Three Temptations: To lure Jesus, The Tempter offers three ways for him to avoid being “broken”:

- **Bread:** The temptation to satisfy one’s own hunger through power (The Addiction of Autonomy).
- **The Pinnacle:** The temptation to perform a miracle to prove one’s “unblemished” status.

¹ *The “Addiction of Autonomy” is a theological and psychological concept that describes a destructive obsession with self-sufficiency. It is the deep-seated belief that to be healthy, successful, or “whole,” one must never rely on anyone else. Timothy L. Sanford, “The Addiction to Autonomy: How to Help Those Who Are Lonely and Don’t Know Why” (2010).*



THE GOLD IN THE FRACTURE

THE INVENTORY OF SHARDS

- **The Kingdom:** The temptation to take the “smooth” path to authority without the “fracture” of the cross.

In each response, Jesus refuses the “shortcut” to perfection. By relying solely on The Word (The Source), **Jesus accepts the reality of being a human vessel—fragile, hungry, and dependent on a power greater than self.**

We often view our “wilderness” seasons—our loneliness, our financial strain, our mental health battles—as a sign that we have been discarded. But the Gospel suggests the opposite. **The wilderness is the Potter’s Gallery.** It is the place where we are “cured,” where the air bubbles of our ego are removed so that when the fire comes, we do not shatter, but are transformed.

MULTI-GENERATIONAL REFLECTION QUESTIONS

- **For Kids:** Have you ever broken something and tried to hide it or “fix” it quickly so no one would see? What would happen if you showed it to someone who could help you turn it into art instead?
- **For Adults:** In which area of your life (career, parenting, or faith) are you working the hardest to look “unblemished”? What “gold” are you missing out on by hiding those cracks?
- **For Elders:** Looking back, which “broken” season of your life did you try to hide at the time, but now realize was actually the most beautiful or important part of your story?



PHYSICAL RITUAL

Pick up a stone, a piece of gravel, or your piece of broken pottery you received on Ash Wednesday. Hold it and name one “fracture” in your life you’ve been hiding. Carry it in your pocket all day.

PRAYER OF THE WEEK

O Holy Artisan, The One who kneads the clay of our lives and walks with us in the heat of the kiln: We thank You for the “box of darkness” and the shards we carry, reminding us that You never discard what is broken.

Grant us the courage to leave behind the theatre of perfection and the exhaustion of trying to mend ourselves alone. As we carry our fractures into the world this week, help us to see every breach as an invitation for Your grace and every scar as a place where Your light might shine.

Breathe Your Spirit into our empty spaces and bind us together in the gold of Your love, until we are transfigured into a new creation. Amen.

SONG OF THE WEEK

Hallelujah by Shawn Mendes

Reflection: As you listen, pay attention to the line, “It’s a cold and it’s a broken Hallelujah.” Notice how worship can be honest even when it is shattered.



POTTERY THROW DOWN

Season 1, Episode 1

“Throwing” & first “Breakages”

Reflection: We often live in the “Cult of the Unblemished,” hiding our cracks. But the potter knows that the kiln—the heat of life—often reveals where the hidden stresses were all along.



THE GOLD IN THE FRACTURE

THE NIGHT OF QUESTIONS

WEEK 2

The Second Week of Lent: The Night of Questions

*"The wind blows where it wants to and you hear its sound.
You do not know where it comes from or where it goes.
It is the same with everyone who is born of the Spirit of God."*

John 3:8, New Life Version

POEM | *The Guest House*

This being human is a guest house.
Every morning a new arrival.

A joy, a depression, a meanness,
some momentary awareness comes
as an unexpected visitor.

Welcome and entertain them all!
Even if they're a crowd of sorrows,
who violently sweep your house
empty of its furniture,
still, treat each guest honorably.
He may be clearing you out
for some new delight.

The dark thought, the shame, the malice,
meet them at the door laughing,
and invite them in.

Be grateful for whoever comes,
because each has been sent
as a guide from beyond.

Rumi

translated by Coleman Bark



READ | *Genesis 12:1–4a*

REFLECT | *Leaving the Smooth Path*

In the quiet of our own “father’s house”—those places where we feel settled, safe, and perhaps a bit stagnant—God speaks a word that shatters our complacency: “Go.” To Abram, this wasn’t just a change of address; it was a total dismantling of his identity. He was told to leave behind his country, his kindred, and the very structures that made him feel “whole.”

Divine blessing rarely arrives as a polish for our current lives; instead, it often begins with a breaking of the familiar.

In the workshop of the soul, the clay can only remain “unblemished” if it stays in the dark of the bag. But to become a vessel of beauty, it must be taken out, slammed onto the potter’s wheel, and subjected to the intense centrifugal force of the spin. This is the place of high tension, where the hands of the Mender press against the clay to find its center.

To follow Jesus, we must be willing to let go of the structures—the political allegiances, social expectations, and religious performances—that once gave us a false sense of wholeness.

Abram’s “Yes” is a courageous leap into the fracture of the unknown. He is not given a map or a five-year plan; he is given only a Promise.

We often cling to our “country and kindred” because they feel smooth and safe, like an unbroken jar sitting on a shelf. **But a jar on a shelf cannot be filled or poured out.** God calls us to be “uprooted” and “re-centered,” promising that the very act of leaving our comfort will make us a blessing for the whole earth.



THE GOLD IN THE FRACTURE

THE NIGHT OF QUESTIONS

READ | *John 3:1-17*

REFLECT | *The Womb and the Kiln*

Nicodemus comes to Jesus under the cover of night—not just to hide from his peers, but because his soul is in a season of shadow. As a powerful religious insider, he is a man with a “complete” theology, a life that looks perfectly unblemished on the outside. Yet, he is drawn to the light because his polished systems are failing him. He is a masterpiece that has begun to crack under the weight of his own questions.

When Nicodemus asks the honest, skeptical question, “How?”, he speaks as an addict of autonomy. He is trying to master the “New Creation” with his intellect, looking for a manual or a formula he can execute himself. **But Jesus refuses to give him a checklist.** Instead, He offers a mystery: the Holy Spirit—the Ruach—the wild, unpredictable Wind of God that blows where it chooses.

In our spiritual journey, “being born again” is not a static event or a one-time catchphrase; it is a labor-intensive process of being “born from above.” In the art of the potter, this is the Raku firing.

In Raku, the vessel is not left to cool slowly in the safety of the kiln. Instead, it is pulled out while it is still glowing-hot—vulnerable and scorched—and plunged into a bed of combustible materials like sawdust or leaves. The sudden shock of the air and the embrace of the flames create a “craze” of beautiful, dark fractures across the surface. The smoke enters these cracks, turning the jagged lines into permanent art.

Jesus invites Nicodemus—and us—to stop trying to master the Law and instead enter the “womb” of the Spirit. This is a place where we lose control, where the “fire” of life’s circumstances meets the “wind” of God’s presence.



It is in this intense, smoking chamber of transformation that we find the Gold: we discover that **God's motive is never condemnation for our fragility, but a world-healing Love that wants to turn our scorch marks into a masterpiece.**

MULTI-GENERATIONAL REFLECTION QUESTIONS

- **For Kids:** Nicodemus had a lot of big questions for Jesus, and he asked them at night when it was quiet. What is a “how” or “why” question you want to ask God today? There are no wrong questions!
- **For Adults:** Abram had to leave his “father’s house”—the place where he felt most “put together”—to find his true purpose. What “comfort zone” or old habit is the Lord asking you to leave behind so that you can be reshaped?
- **For Elders:** Jesus talks about being “born again” even when we are old. How have you experienced a “new beginning” or a fresh “birth” later in your life? How did that change the way you see your own history?



THE GOLD IN THE FRACTURE

THE NIGHT OF QUESTIONS

PHYSICAL RITUAL

This week, find a dark space in your home. Sit in the dark for three minutes each night. Don't try to "fix" anything or plan anything. Just breathe and say: "Holy Spirit, breathe into my cracks."

PRAYER OF THE WEEK

Almighty Source, Your Spirit blows where it will, moving through the breaches of our lives. Like Abram, give us the courage to leave the "smooth" path for the sake of your Promise.

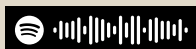
Like Nicodemus, give us the humility to ask "How?" in the middle of the night. We thank you that your motive is not to judge our brokenness, but to love the world into wholeness through Jesus Christ.

Carry us through the fire, until we are born again into your golden light. Amen.

SONG OF THE WEEK

The Sound of Silence
by Simon & Garfunkel

Reflection: In the song, the "silence" is described as a growth or a shadow; in your own life this week, is your silence a place where you are hiding your cracks from God, or is it a "quiet womb" where you are finally allowing the Holy Spirit to begin the mending?



POTTERY THROW DOWN

Season 3, Episode 3
"Raku" episode

Reflection: Watch how the fire and smoke create beautiful "fractures" and markings that the potters didn't plan for. Like Nicodemus, the potters have to wait in the dark to see how their pieces turned out. Sometimes the most beautiful colors only appear because of the "terror" of the fire.





THE GOLD IN THE FRACTURE

THE WELL OF TRUTH

WEEK 3

The Third Week of Lent: The Well of Truth

*“The water that I will give will become in them
a spring of water gushing up to eternal life.”*

John 4:14, NRSVUE

POEM | *Blessing the Boats*

(at St. Mary’s)

may the tide
that is entering even now
the lip of our understanding
carry you out
beyond the face of fear
may you kiss
the wind then turn from it

certain that it will
love your back
may you open your eyes to
water
water waving forever
and may you in your innocence
sail through this to that

Lucille Clifton

from “Blessing the Boats: New and Selected Poems” 1988-2000. Copyright © 2000

READ | *Exodus 17:1–7*

REFLECT | *The Hardness of the Heart*

The community is wandering in the desert, and they are parched. In their dehydration, their thirst turns to litigation—they “quarrel” with Moses and “test” the Lord, demanding: “Is the Lord among us or not?”

Thirst makes us mean. It makes us cynical. When we are spiritually dehydrated, we tend to strike out at others—blaming our leaders,



our families, or our circumstances—rather than admitting our own deep, hollow need. We build a “Rock” of hardness around our hearts to protect ourselves from the pain of being empty.

But notice how God responds: Not with a lecture, but with a miracle. **God brings life-giving water out of a Rock—the very symbol of hardness and impossibility.** In the workshop of the Mender, the mending begins the moment we stop pretending we are self-sufficient. The water flows exactly where we are the hardest.

READ | *John 4:5-42*

REFLECT | *The Well of Honesty*

Jesus, weary and thirsty, sits at a well in the heat of the day. When a Samaritan woman approaches, he does the unthinkable: he asks her for a drink. In this one request, Jesus breaks every social, racial, and gendered “fracture” of his time. **He steps across the jagged edges of “us vs. them” to meet a person in her need.**

For centuries, this woman has been unfairly painted as a “sinner” to be judged. But look closer: she is a truth-seeker. She carries the “shards” of five broken relationships, a history of being discarded or disconnected. She is living in the “Cult of the Unblemished”¹ in reverse—everyone sees her cracks, and she has learned to hide in the heat of the noon sun. Yet, she is the very first person in the Gospel to whom Jesus explicitly reveals his identity.

“Living Water” isn’t a reward for finally getting our lives “clean”; it is the agent that cleanses the shards so the gold can finally stick. Jesus doesn’t tell her to go fix her life, find a way to be “unblemished,” and

¹ The “Cult of the Unblemished” is a cultural or religious mindset that prizes perfection, performance, and the appearance of “having it all together” over the messy, authentic, and broken reality of the human experience. Timothy L. Sanford, *“The Addiction to Autonomy: How to Help Those Who Are Lonely and Don’t Know Why”* (2010).



then come back for a drink. Instead, **he invites her to see that the “Well of Truth” is already bubbling up within her.**

In Kintsugi, the broken pieces must be washed thoroughly. The grit of shame and the dust of our “Addiction to Autonomy” (thinking we must fix ourselves) must be rinsed away by the truth. Jesus washes her story with honesty, not to shame her, but to prepare her to be made whole.

MULTI-GENERATIONAL REFLECTION QUESTIONS

- **For Kids:** Have you ever noticed that when you are really thirsty or hungry, you get a little “cranky” or mean? How does a cold glass of water change how you feel inside? God wants to give our hearts that same kind of “refresh” when we feel mean or sad.
- **For Adults:** The woman at the well went at noon to avoid being seen. What part of your “story” or your “shards” are you trying to hide from the light? What would it feel like to let Jesus wash that part of your life with his “Living Water” (Grace) instead of your own “Soap” (Effort)?
- **For Elders:** You have likely seen many “Rocks” in your life—situations that seemed impossible or people who seemed too hard to change. Where have you seen the Lord bring water out of those hard places when you least expected it?

PHYSICAL RITUAL

This week, every time you take a drink of water, pause. Think of one “shard” of your life (a regret, a worry, or a secret) and imagine the water washing the “grit” off it so it’s ready to be mended.



PRAYER OF THE WEEK

Holy Mender, we come to you parched, often hiding our thirst behind the “rocks” of our own making. Forgive us for the addiction to autonomy that tells us we must be our own source.

Lord Jesus, you who sat weary at the well: thank you for meeting us in the heat of our shame. Thank you for seeing the “shards” of our history not as reasons for judgment, but as pieces to be washed in truth.

Holy Spirit, flow through our jagged spaces. Rinse away the grit of self-doubt and the dust of our hiding. Turn our hardness into a spring of Living Water, that we might pour out your grace for a thirsty world. Amen.

SONG OF THE WEEK

Bridge Over Troubled Water
by Jacob Collier

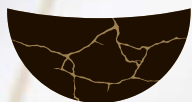
Reflection: *Collier’s arrangement takes a familiar, “smooth” song and breaks it apart into thousands of tiny, shimmering harmonies. Where in your life is God taking something you thought was “simple” or “settled” and breaking it open to reveal a much deeper, more complex beauty? Can you hear the music in the tension?*



POTTERY THROW DOWN

Season 4, Episode 1
“Cheese Cellar” challenge

Reflection: *Focus on structural integrity and clay preparation. What are the “air bubbles” in your own life—the small areas of dishonesty, hidden shame, or the “Addiction to Autonomy”—that make you feel fragile? How might letting Jesus “wash” and “re-wedge” those parts of your story give you the structural integrity to carry the Living Water to others?*



THE GOLD IN THE FRACTURE

THE SIGHT OF THE HEART

WEEK 4

The Fourth Week of Lent: The Sight of the Heart

*"The Lord doesn't see things the way you see them.
People judge by outward appearance, but the Lord looks at the heart"*

1 Samuel 16:7, The New Living Translation

POEM | *The Thing Is*

to love life, to love it even
when you have no stomach for it
and everything you've held dear
crumbles like burnt paper in your hands,
your throat filled with the silt of it.
When grief sits with you, its tropical heat
thickening the air, heavy as water
more fit for gills than lungs;
when grief weights you down like your own flesh
only more of it, an obesity of grief,
you think, How can a body withstand this?
Then you hold life like a face
between your palms, a plain face,
no charming smile, no violet eyes,
and you say, yes, I will take you
I will love you, again.

Ellen Bass

from "Mules of Love." Copyright © 2002



READ | *1 Samuel 16:1-13*

REFLECT | *The Discarded King*

Samuel is sent to anoint a king, and he naturally looks for a “statuesque” leader—someone who fits the mold of worldly power. He looks at the brothers who are “whole,” the ones who look the part, the unbroken ones.

God rejects the obvious. The Lord says to Samuel, “Do not look on his appearance or on the height of his stature... for the Lord does not see as mortals see.” The king is eventually found in David—the youngest, the one left out in the field, the one essentially “discarded” from the lineup.

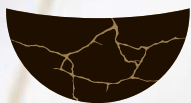
In the art of *kintsugi*, a beginner might look at a pile of shards and see only trash to be thrown away. **But the Master Artisan looks at those same shards and sees the architecture of a masterpiece.** Divine authority often resides in the “shards” that the systems of power have overlooked. God does not need a “perfect” vessel to lead; God needs a heart that is open to being shaped.

READ | *John 9:1-41*

REFLECT | *Optics vs. Insight*

When the disciples see a man born blind, their first instinct is to find someone to blame. They see a “problem” to be solved or a “sin” to be judged. They are stuck in the Cult of the Unblemished, where anything less than physical “perfection” is seen as a failure.

Jesus completely re-frames the situation. **He doesn’t see a defect; He sees an opportunity for the “works of God” to be revealed.** He uses the very “clay” of the earth to bring sight. Paradoxically, the man who was “broken” by blindness is the only one who truly “sees”



THE GOLD IN THE FRACTURE

THE SIGHT OF THE HEART

who Jesus is, while the “whole” religious leaders are blinded by their own certainty and polished reputations.

Sight is not about optics; it is about insight. **Healing, in this story, isn't about making the man “normal” so he can fit back into a broken system.** It is about making him a witness to a Light that the “normal” world cannot comprehend. The “gold” in this man's life wasn't the restoration of his eyes, but the opening of his soul. He became beautiful not because he was finally “fixed,” but because his story became a window into the glory of God.

MULTI-GENERATIONAL REFLECTION QUESTIONS

- **For Kids:** Samuel thought the biggest, strongest brother would be King, but God chose the youngest brother from the fields. Have you ever felt like you were “too small” or “not good enough” to help out? How does it feel to know God sees the hero inside you?
- **For Adults:** The disciples looked for “fault” in the blind man. When you look at your own “broken” parts, do you see a “fault” to be ashamed of, or an “opportunity” for God to show God's love? What would change if you looked at your scars through God's eyes?
- **For Elders:** You have lived through many “certainties” that turned out to be wrong. Like the blind man, when has losing something (like your youth, your health, or a career) actually helped you see what matters most more clearly?

PHYSICAL RITUAL

Find something “broken” in your house (a chipped mug, a torn book). Place it on your dining table as a “centerpiece” of grace for the week. **Bonus Ritual:** Put on a pair of sunglasses or a blindfold for five minutes today. Navigate a familiar room slowly. Notice how your other senses wake up.



PRAYER OF THE WEEK

Master Artisan, forgive us for judging by outward appearance. Open our eyes to see the kings and queens you have hidden in the fields, and the masterpieces you are building out of our forgotten shards.

Lord Jesus, Heal our blindness. Not the blindness of our eyes, but of our hearts. When we see only “faults” in our history, help us to see instead an opportunity for your glory to be revealed.

Holy Spirit, Give us the insight of the heart. Remind us that we are beautiful—not because we are flawless, but because we are yours. Fill our fractures with your presence until we see the world through your eyes of gold. Amen.

SONG OF THE WEEK

Beautiful by India.Arie

Reflection: If you stripped away your “outward appearance” and your “stature,” what would remain? Can you see the “Gold” that God sees when God looks at your heart?

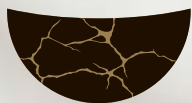


POTTERY THROW DOWN

Season 3, Episode 6

“Greek Statues” challenge

Reflection: Watch how the potters try to create “perfect” forms and where the clay inevitably “slumps” or cracks. How much energy do you spend trying to maintain a “statuesque” or “unbroken” image for the world to see? If you allowed yourself to “slump” or show your cracks, how might that create space for God to reveal the masterpiece God is building from the inside out?



THE GOLD IN THE FRACTURE

THE BREATH IN THE CRACKS

WEEK 5

The Fifth Week of Lent: The Breath in the Cracks

“He said to me, ‘Prophecy to the breath. Prophecy, son of man. Tell the breath, ‘God, the Master, says, Come from the four winds. Come, breath. Breathe on these slain bodies. Breathe life!’”

Ezekiel 37:9, The Message

POEM | *Blessing of Breathing*

That the first breath
will come without fear.

That the second breath
will come without pain.

The third breath:
that it will come without
despair.

And the fourth,
without anxiety.

That the fifth breath
will come with no bitterness.

That the sixth breath
will come for joy.

Breath seven:
that it will come for love.

May the eighth breath
come for freedom.

And the ninth,
for delight.

When the tenth breath comes,
may it be for us
to breathe together,
and the next,
and the next,
until our breathing
is as one,
until our breathing
is no more.

Jan Richardson

from “The Cure for Sorrow: A Book of Blessings for Times of Grief.” © 2020



READ | *Ezekiel 37:1-14*

REFLECT | *The Rattle of the Shards*

The Prophet Ezekiel is dropped into a valley of “very dry” bones. These are not just skeletons; they are the ultimate shards—**a people who have lost their hope, their home, and their sense of self.** They are scattered, bleached by the sun, and disconnected.

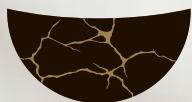
God does not ask Ezekiel for a technical plan on how to fix the bones. Instead, our God asks a question of the heart: “Can these bones live?” **The mending begins with a “rattle”**—the sound of pieces finding one another, of bone joining to bone. But as Ezekiel observes, a collection of parts is not yet a person. Even with skin and muscle, they remain a corpse until the Breath (the Ruach) comes from the four winds.

In the journey of mending, connection without Spirit is just a pile of parts. We can glue our lives back together, we can attend all the right meetings, and we can say all the right words, but it is **the Breath of God that turns a collection of shards into a living, breathing Body.** The gold in the cracks is only beautiful because the Spirit shines through it.

READ | *John 11:1-45*

REFLECT | *Facing the Stench*

Jesus stands before the tomb of his friend Lazarus. This is the ultimate fracture; the break of death is four days old, and the “stench” of reality has set in. **There is no hiding the decay; there is no pretending that things are “fine.”**



THE GOLD IN THE FRACTURE

THE BREATH IN THE CRACKS

Jesus does not offer a platitude. He is “deeply moved”—**He weeps at the break.** He acknowledges the agony of the fracture before he mends it. Then, Jesus commands the breath to return. He calls Lazarus out of the dark, still bound in his “shards” (the grave clothes). Lazarus doesn’t emerge “un-broken” or “un-affected” by his time in the tomb; he emerges as a man who has passed through death into a new kind of life.

Resurrection often requires us to face the “stink” of our deepest hurts. **We cannot find the gold if we are unwilling to go into the dark of the tomb.** Jesus calls us out not to be “normal” again, but to be people who have transitioned from the stillness of death to the movement of breath. Our “grave clothes”—the old habits and fears that bind us—must be unwrapped so that the world can see the mending God has done.

MULTI-GENERATIONAL REFLECTION QUESTIONS

- **For Kids:** Have you ever tried to put a puzzle together and found out a piece was missing? In Ezekiel’s story, God finds all the “missing pieces” and brings them together with a big, happy “rattle!” How does it feel to know God never loses a piece of you?
- **For Adults:** Lazarus was called out of the tomb while still wrapped in his grave clothes. What “old bandages” (past hurts, old labels, or defensive habits) are you still wearing even though Jesus has called you into new life? Who can help you “unwrap” them?
- **For Elders:** Ezekiel speaks to a people who felt their “hope was lost.” In seasons where you felt “dried up” or spiritually exhausted, how did the Holy Spirit breathe new life or a “second wind” back into your soul?



PHYSICAL RITUAL

Practice “Box Breathing” (4 seconds in, 4 hold, 4 out, 4 hold). Imagine God’s gold filling the empty spaces in your chest. **Bonus Ritual:** Go for a walk outside. Every time you feel the wind on your face, take a deep breath and say: “*Breath of God, live in my shards.*”

PRAYER OF THE WEEK

Sacred Breath, you are the God of the Valley and the God of the Tomb. When our hope is dry and our pieces are scattered, give us the faith to hear the “rattle” of your mending.

Lord Jesus, thank you for weeping with us in our fractures and for calling us by name out of the dark. Help us to face the “stink” of our deepest hurts so that we may experience the sweetness of your life.

Holy Spirit, breathe upon us. Turn our collection of parts into a living body. Unwrap our grave clothes and lead us into the light, where our cracks are filled with your golden glory. Amen.

SONG OF THE WEEK

Keep Breathing
by Ingrid Michaelson

Reflection: When your life feels like a “Large Scale” challenge—too heavy to support its own weight—can you stop trying to “fix” the cracks for a moment and just focus on the Breath? How does it feel to realize that every breath you take is a sign that the Spirit hasn’t given up on your mending?



POTTERY THROW DOWN

Season 4, Episode 10
“The Grand Final”

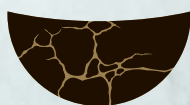
Reflection: Where in your life are you “cracking” because you are trying to carry too much on your own? Are you willing to let the “Breath of God” (the Spirit) be the internal scaffolding that supports you, rather than relying on the strength of your own clay?



Part II

THE HOLY WEEK PATH: THE GREAT MENDING

This week, we follow the Master Artisan into the heart of the fire. We move from the shouting crowds of Palm Sunday—who want a King to “fix” their fractures—to the quiet Upper Room, and finally to the silence of the Skull. In this one week, Jesus takes the “breaking” of the entire world into his own Body.



THE GOLD IN
THE FRACTURE
THE HUMBLE ENTRY



THE GOLD IN
THE FRACTURE
THE BINDING COMMANDMENT



THE GOLD IN
THE FRACTURE
THE COST OF THE CURE



THE GOLD IN THE FRACTURE

THE GREAT MENDING

WEEK 6

Holy Week: The Great Mending

*“He was wounded for our rebellious acts. He was crushed for our sins.
He was punished so that we could have peace,
and we received healing from his wounds.”*

Isaiah 53:5, Names of God Bible

POEM | *Holy Saturday*

The sky is still dark,
or maybe it has come
and gone again.

This is a vigil,
but not for Easter.

Keeping time is tragic,
so we drift
in and out of sleep,
and puffy eyes observe
only the piles of ointment
and death clothes

stacked and weary
near the back door.

Maybe you can
decorate and bake,
but some of us can only wait
in the silence between
what is already and not yet.
These are holy hours
to consider how far
God is willing to go
for love.

Rev. Meta Herrick Carlson

from *“Speak It Plain: Words for Worship and Life Together.”* © 2020



For Palm Sunday

READ | *Matthew 21:1-11*



THE GOLD IN
THE FRACTURE
THE HUMBLE ENTRY

REFLECT | *The Mender on a Donkey*

The crowds throw down their cloaks and palm branches, shouting “Hosanna!”—literally, “Save us, now!” They are desperate for a hero to mend their broken nation.

The crowd wants a “fixer” on a warhorse; they get a Mender on a donkey. They cheer for a victory that will look like a defeat. They don’t realize that the “saving” will happen not through the king’s crown, but through the king’s breaking. We often ask God to fix our circumstances; God responds by entering our fractures.

True mending doesn’t always look like a triumph. Sometimes, the most powerful thing God does is refuse to “overpower” our pain, choosing instead to “under-power” it—supporting us from beneath, like a donkey carrying the weight of the world.

For Maundy Thursday

READ | *John 13:1-17, 31b-35*



THE GOLD IN
THE FRACTURE
THE BINDING COMMANDMENT

REFLECT | *Tactile Love*

Knowing his “hour” had come, Jesus strips down to a towel and washes the dusty, calloused feet of his friends. He is the Master Potter becoming the servant of the clay.

He touches the “shards” of their humanity—their dirt, their travel-weariness, and eventually, their betrayal (even washing the feet of



THE GOLD IN THE FRACTURE

THE GREAT MENDING

Judas). He gives a new commandment: “Just as I have loved you, you also should love one another.”

Love is not a feeling; it is a tactile labor. In Kintsugi, the artisan must touch every jagged edge to apply the gold. Love is the gold that fills the space between the “Master” and the “Servant,” erasing the hierarchy of the break. To love as Jesus loves is to be willing to get the dust of someone else’s brokenness under our fingernails.

For Good Friday

READ | *Isaiah 52:13-53:12*



THE GOLD IN
THE FRACTURE
THE COST OF THE CURE

REFLECT | *The Gold in the Wound*

The “Suffering Servant” is described as one with “no form or majesty that we should look at him,” someone from whom people hide their faces.

We are conditioned to look for God in “unbroken” places—success, power, and physical perfection. But Isaiah points us toward the Pierced One. He is the ultimate “discarded shard.”

By his bruises, we are healed.” In the economy of the Cross, the “bruise” and the “healing” are not separate events; they are fused. The gold is the wound of God. We aren’t healed by Jesus taking our place so we can stay “perfect”; we are healed because He joined His brokenness to ours, making the seam stronger than the original vessel.



MULTI-GENERATIONAL REFLECTION QUESTIONS

- **For Kids:** On Palm Sunday, the people were happy, but by Friday, they were sad. Have you ever had a week where your feelings changed a lot? How does it feel to know God stays with you in the happy times and the sad times?
- **For Adults:** Jesus washed the feet of those he knew would betray or abandon Him. Who are the “difficult shards” in your life that you are being called to touch with love this week?
- **For Elders:** You have survived many “Good Fridays.” Looking back, can you see a time when a “defeat” or a “breaking” in your life actually became the place where God’s strongest mending happened?

PHYSICAL RITUAL

Keep a small ceramic shard or a smooth stone in your pocket this week. Every time you touch it, remember that Jesus took the “edges” of our brokenness upon himself so we wouldn’t have to be cut by them anymore.



PRAYER OF THE WEEK

Weaver of Scars, this week, we lay down the heavy burden of trying to be “whole” on our own. We stop hiding our cracks, remembering they are the very places where your light intends to shine.

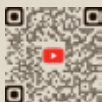
Lord Jesus, thank you for the donkey, the towel, and the nails. Thank you for not flinching when you touch the jagged edges of our lives—the parts of our story that are still sharp and hurting. Thank you for being the Divine Gold that flows into our fractures and refuses to let us stay shattered.

Holy Spirit, breathe peace into our restless hearts. Help us to wait with courage in the silence of Saturday, trusting that even when we cannot see the progress, your mending is almost complete. Turn our wounds into windows of your grace. Amen.

SONG OF THE WEEK

Hurt by Johnny Cash

Reflection: *This song is raw, weary, and honest about the “crown of thorns.” It strips away the polish of religion to reveal the “empire of dirt” we often build. As you listen, imagine the Gold of the Resurrection beginning to seep into those dark, hurt places Cash sings about.*



POTTERY THROW DOWN

Season 4, Episode 9

“Pedestal sinks & chamber pots”

Reflection: *A sink is designed to catch dirt and channel water; it is a vessel made for cleansing. As you watch them labor over these “thrones of washing,” think of Jesus at the basin. Are you willing to let Him wash the “grit” of your journey away, or are you trying to keep your “pedestal” clean on your own?*

AN INVITATION INTO THE FIRE: THE THREE-DAY CHALLENGE

To understand the beauty of a mended vessel, you cannot simply look at the finished product on a shelf. You have to witness the breaking, the washing, and the firing.

In the tradition of the church, the **three days** from Thursday sundown to Sunday sundown are known as the **Triduum**—a single, continuous liturgy that leads us through the heart of the Master Artisan’s workshop.

I want to **challenge** you this week to attend or observe all three days.

We often want to skip from the “Hosannas” of Palm Sunday straight to the “Alleluias” of Easter, bypassing the mess in between. But if you skip the middle, you miss the mending. To fully experience the joy of the Resurrection, you must first stand in the shadow of the Cross.

- **Maundy Thursday (The Washing):** Come and feel the tactile love of the Artisan. Watch as the Master stoops to touch the “shards” of our humanity. Without this night, we don’t understand that God’s gold is found in service and humility.
- **Good Friday (The Breaking):** Come and stand at the foot of the Cross. This is the moment the Vessel is shattered. We must face the “stink” of the tomb and the sharp edges of the sacrifice to realize that God does not fear our brokenness—God inhabits it.
- **The Easter Vigil/Sunday (The Masterpiece):** Only after the silence of Saturday does the morning light reveal the work. When you see the risen Christ, you will notice he still carries his scars. They are no longer wounds; they are the gold seams of a new, indestructible life.

If you only show up for the celebration, you are seeing a “fix.” But if you **walk through the Three Days**, you are **witnessing a Mending**. You will see that Easter isn’t about God making us “new” by erasing our past; it’s about God making us “whole” by weaving our past into a glorious future. Don’t look away from the process. The fire of the kiln is where the gold is set. You are invited.



THE GOLD IN THE FRACTURE

THE GLORIFIED REVEAL

WEEK 7

Easter: The Glorified Reveal

*“Then He who sat on the throne said, ‘Behold, I make all things new.’
And He said to me, ‘Write, for these words are true and faithful.’”*

Revelation 21:5 New King James Version

POEM | *Still I Rise*

You may write me down in history
With your bitter, twisted lies,
You may trod me in the very dirt
But still, like dust, I’ll rise.

Does my sassiness upset you?
Why are you beset with gloom?
’Cause I walk like I’ve got oil wells
Pumping in my living room.

Just like moons and like suns,
With the certainty of tides,
Just like hopes springing high,
Still I’ll rise.

Did you want to see me broken?
Bowed head and lowered eyes?
Shoulders falling down like teardrops,
Weakened by my soulful cries?

Does my haughtiness offend you?
Don’t you take it awful hard
’Cause I laugh like I’ve got gold mines
Diggin’ in my own backyard.



You may shoot me with your words,
You may cut me with your eyes,
You may kill me with your hatefulness,
But still, like air, I'll rise.

Does my sexiness upset you?
Does it come as a surprise
That I dance like I've got diamonds
At the meeting of my thighs?

Out of the huts of history's shame
I rise
Up from a past that's rooted in pain
I rise

I'm a black ocean, leaping and wide,
Welling and swelling I bear in the tide.

Leaving behind nights of terror and fear
I rise

Into a daybreak that's wondrously clear
I rise

Bringing the gifts that my ancestors gave,
I am the dream and the hope of the slave.

I rise

I rise

I rise.

Maya Angelou

from "And Still I Rise: A Book of Poems." © 1978



THE GOLD IN THE FRACTURE

THE GLORIFIED REVEAL

READ | *Jeremiah 31:1-6*

REFLECT | *The Constant Rebuilding*

Jeremiah speaks to a people who have known only displacement and destruction. To them, God gives a promise not of a single repair, but of a persistent, faithful reconstruction: “Again I will build you, and you shall be built.”

God’s “building” is a recursive act. It is a promise that no matter how many times the vessel breaks or how often the clay feels discarded, the “everlasting love”—our Divine Gold—is the constant. We are not a people who are “fixed” once and for all; **we are a people being continuously built and re-built.**

The sign of our mending isn’t just that we are standing; it’s that we are dancing. God calls us to “take up our tambourines” and join the dance even in our mended state. The gold doesn’t just hold us together; it makes us resonant and ready for joy.

READ | *John 20:1-18*

REFLECT | *The Kintsugi King*

Mary Magdalene stands at the empty tomb, blinded by her grief. She does not recognize the Resurrected Jesus until he calls her name. Later, when Jesus appears to the disciples, he doesn’t just show them his face; he shows them his hands and his side.

The Resurrected Body is a Kintsugi Body. **Jesus does not hide the “fractures” of the nails or the spear.** He does not return with a “polished mask” of someone who never suffered. Instead, he presents his scars as his credentials of victory. **The holes in his hands are where the glory shines through most brightly.**



We recognize the Divine not by a lack of scars, but by how those scars have been mended. Resurrection is not the removal of our history; it is the gold becoming the strongest part of the vessel. The “new life” of Easter is a life where our fractures are no longer sources of pain, but witnesses to the Master Artisan’s power to bring us back from the dark.

MULTI-GENERATIONAL REFLECTION QUESTIONS

- **For Kids:** Think back to the very start of our journey. We learned that even though we are made of “dust” and “clay,” we are God’s favorite creation. Sometimes we feel “broken”—maybe we had a bad day, felt lonely, or made a mistake that felt like a “crack” in our hearts.

Imagine God is a Master Artist who has spent the last few weeks painting gold over every one of your “boo-boos” and “cracks.”

- If you looked in a mirror today, where would your Golden Scars be?
- Did God put gold on your heart when you were brave?
- Did God put gold on your hands when you helped a friend?

- **For Adults:** We have spent this series moving away from the “Fix-It” mentality (which tries to erase the past) and toward a “Mending” mentality (which honors the history of the vessel).

In the “Large Scale” challenges of your life this season, where did you find that your own strength failed, but the “Breath” of the Spirit held you together? How does seeing the scars on the Resurrected Christ give you permission to stop hiding the “seams” in your own story?

- **For Elders:** Jeremiah 31 reminds us that God’s love is “everlasting”—it is the gold that never runs out, no matter how many times the vessel is dropped or the heart is broken.



THE GOLD IN THE FRACTURE

THE GLORIFIED REVEAL

You have a long history of being “built and re-built.” Looking at the “Gallery” of your life today, how has the “rattle” of your difficult seasons eventually turned into the “tambourine” of praise? How can you help the younger generations trust that the fire of the kiln is not the end of the story?

PHYSICAL RITUAL

Take a piece of gold ribbon or gold tape. Wrap it around your wrist or a finger as a “ring of remembrance.” As you wear it, let it be a tactile reminder that you are precious and mended. Let it represent the “Everlasting Love” from Jeremiah that binds you together. Let it remind you that you are not “damaged goods”; you are a vessel held by the gold of our resurrected God.

SONG OF THE WEEK

Rise Up by Andra Day

Reflection: *This song is a modern anthem of Resurrection. It acknowledges the weariness—the “broken down” feeling of the struggle—but insists on the rising. “I’ll rise up / Rise like the day / I’ll rise up / In spite of the ache.” This is the Easter story. We don’t rise because the ache is gone; we rise in spite of it, because the Master Artisan has breathed life into our shards once more.*



POTTERY THROW DOWN

Any Season Finale
the “Grand Gallery”

Reflection: *The potters stand before their finished collections, seeing their journey from raw clay to fired art. Tears usually fall not just because of the “Potter of the Year” announcement, but because they are seeing their own resilience reflected in the vessels they made. When God looks at your life today, God doesn’t see a “seconds” bin of broken parts. God sees a Gallery of Grace. God sees every crack that was filled with God’s Spirit and every fire you survived. How would it change your walk today if you saw yourself as God’s “Potter of the Year”—a masterpiece of persistence and mending?*



AN EASTER BLESSING

Weaver of Scars and Giver of Breath,
May you go forth from this season
knowing that you are God's masterpiece in progress.
May you no longer hide your fractures in the shadows of shame,
but hold them up to the sun,
letting the world see the gold of grace that keeps you whole.

When the world feels heavy and your strength feels small,
remember the Divine Scaffolding that supports you.
When the "rattle" of life's breaks begins to sound,
listen for the Hosanna of the Mender
who refuses to let you stay in pieces.

May you carry your scars
with the dignity of the Risen King,
recognizing that your mended places
are now your strongest seams.

Go now, built and re-built,
to be a living witness that nothing is ever truly discarded
in the hands of the Master Artisan.

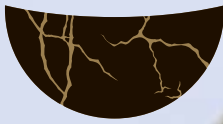
Take up your tambourine,
breathe deep of the Spirit,
and dance in the light of the Great Mending.

Alleluia!

The Masterpiece is revealed.
Amen.

Thank you for journeying with me, faith family.
Easter blessings to you and yours.

In Christ,
David Horton, *Minister of Music & Worship*



THE GOLD IN THE FRACTURE

A LENTEN JOURNEY OF MENDING

*"There is a crack in everything,
that's how the light gets in."*

Leonard Cohen

*"Our scars are the map of where we have been,
but they do not have to be the map
of where we are going."*

Unknown

"God is closest to those with broken hearts."

Jewish Proverb

*"Maybe you weren't broken.
Maybe you were being shed.
Like a seed, you have to break open to grow."*

Cynthia Ocelli

*"The wound is the place
where the Light enters you."*

Rumi

TRINITY LUTHERAN CHURCH & SCHOOLS

6215 196th St, SW, Lynnwood, WA 98037 | 425.778.2159 | trinitylutheranchurch.com